



Who LOSES

- The national security adviser, to whom the JIC, NTRO, Aviation Research Centre apart from IB and R&AW report to, will lose his importance.
- The IB director will play second fiddle to the NCTC director in counter-terrorism efforts. The Multi-Agency Centre and its subsidiaries in the state capitals will come under the NCTC's control.

wants is to prevent duplication of work. For example, three satellite-monitoring systems operated by the Research and Analysis Wing (R&AW), IB and National Technical Research Organisation (NTRO) in south Delhi listen in on satellite phones favoured by terrorists. And they all provide identical intercepts resulting in utterly wasteful duplication.

The problem arises when Chidambaram talks about agencies under other ministries to report to him. "Under the Government of India Allocation of Business Rules, 1961, he cannot suo moto decide that organisations, under other ministries, like R&AW, NTRO, Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) or the Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) should report to him," the official adds.

Sources say that before publicly announcing his proposal, Chidambaram should have first circulated a Cabinet note to elicit views from the concerned ministries. It was after the home minister was gently reminded by the PMO about the procedure that a note is now being prepared and will be put up before the Cabinet Committee on Security (CCS) for approval.

The Home Ministry revamp chips away at the power of the prime minister and the Cabinet Secretariat which has housed major security organisations created after the 1962 war with China—the Directorate-General Security (DGS) and R&AW. Wary of her powerful home minister Yashwantrao Chavan, the then prime minister Indira Gandhi placed these organisations under her direct control, a tradition that has continued under successive prime Ministers. Chidambaram's proposal restores the primacy of the Home Ministry in the internal security matrix but it could also lead to over-centralisation, warn security experts. "To fight terror we need empowerment at the local level rather than a monolithic organisation in Delhi deciding everything," says Ajai Sahni, executive director, Institute for Conflict Management.

The immediate impact of the Home Ministry revamp is in the pow-

ers of the NSA. Before the 26/11 attacks and Chidambaram's appointment, Narayanan, only the third individual to occupy the post created under the A.B. Vajpayee government in 1998, directly reported to Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. As with previous NSAs Brajesh Mishra and J.N. Dixit, Narayanan's responsibilities encompassed a broad sweep of strategic affairs and foreign policy. He advised the prime minister on border talks with China and Pakistan, besides forming an important part of the Nuclear Command Authority. The heads of the Joint Intelligence Committee (JIC) to analyse intelligence inputs and the NTRO formally report to Narayanan. Prior to 26/11, most coordination meetings chaired by the NSA invariably degenerated into a show of one-upmanship.

The process of reducing the NSA's importance in the security set-up began with Chidambaram's daily security meetings after the 26/11 attacks. The purpose was to ensure better coordination and intelligence-sharing among various agencies with the NSA, home secretary, secretary R&AW, director IB, JIC chairman, and special secretary (Internal Security) in attendance. Prior to this, Home Ministry old-timers hardly remember an occasion when the NSA was summoned to North Block for meetings. "It has always been the home minister visiting the NSA in his office at South Block. In fact, there have been occasions when Chidambaram's predecessor Shivraj Patil had to wait to meet the NSA," says a senior Home Ministry official. Chidambaram's logic is simple: he is a cabinet minister while the NSA is equivalent to a minister of state.

In the new scheme, everybody is expected to report to the home minister because the NCTC will be under him. The proposal will dilute the NSA's powers and turn him from an intelligence czar back to an adviser.

Chidambaram's NCTC proposal mirrors the United States' which, following the 9/11 attacks, set up an NCTC responsible for the collection of intelligence to warn of terror attacks and